

GLUT OF **OPTIONS** A HAPPY HEADACHE

Neeraj Chopra, the reigning Olympic champion and 2023 World Championships gold medalist, will **likely remain the standard** bearer of Indian athletics in Paris.

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The year 2023 was a remarkable one for Indian athletics. The country achieved its best-ever medal tally at the Asian Games and won its first-ever World

Championship gold medal. However, the true measure of sports development will be seen during the 2024 Olympic season.

Although nine Indians have already met the qualification standards for the Paris Games, there's still some way to go to match the record of 23 who competed in Tokyo three years ago. But it's not unlikely that India will have a similar number eventually earn the right to compete at the Olympics. While more athletes are expected to match the qualification standards, others are likely to qualify based on rankings by the June 30 cut-off date.

Neeraj Chopra will likely remain the standard bearer of Indian athletics in Paris. The reigning Olympic champion qualified for the quadrennial games after creating history by winning gold at the 2023 World Championships. He will be one of the favourites to medal. While

Neeraj might be India's best bet in the men's javelin throw competition, he's not the only one. India is theoretically permitted a maximum of three participants in each event at the Olympics (assuming they meet the qualification criteria of an 85.5m throw inside the qualification period). Two Indians — Neeraj and Kishore Kumar Jena — have already met these standards. Currently, there are three others— Rohit Yadav, DP Manu, and Shivpal Yadav — who are either close to the qualification standard or (as in the case of Shivpal) exceeded it in the past.

It is possible that Indian athletics may face a scenario where an athlete meets the strict Olympic qualification standard but still fails to secure a place on the national team. Adille Sumariwalla, the president of the Athletics Federation of India, has stated that if more than three Indian javelin throwers meet the qualifying criteria, then a process must be devised to select the other two participants, excluding Neeraj. This implies that even an athlete like Jena, who qualified for the Olympics with an impressive throw of 87.54m at the Asian Games, may have to further improve his personal best to ensure his spot at the Olympics.

Should Jena make it to the Paris

Games, it would be a tremendous milestone in the 28-year-old's career, which only really took off in 2023 when he made his international debut. While it remains to be seen how he holds his nerve should he compete at the Olympics, there are other Indians who would have the experience of competing at the biggest stage in track and field athletics.

Avinash Sable has been a standout performer in India's individual track events over the past Olympic cycle. During his debut Olympics in Tokyo back in 2021, the now-29-year-old broke his national record in the men's 3000m steeplechase in the heats and broke it three more times in 2022, when he also achieved a historic silver medal-winning performance to break the Kenyan hegemony at the Commonwealth Games. Although he won gold and a silver medal at the Asian Games, 2023 has been a less-than-stellar year for Sable by his lofty standards. The biggest disappointment would be his crashing out in the heats of the Budapest World Championships.

Sable, though, admitted he ran a tactically poor race in Hungary and has vowed not to make that same mistake in Paris. Expect fireworks if